

Imposter Pictionary — Game Description and Rules

1. Game Concept

Imposter Pictionary is a social deduction drawing game inspired by classic Pictionary. In normal Pictionary, the artist tries to draw a word clearly so that other players can guess it. In this version, one player is secretly assigned as the **Imposter**.

The twist is that the Imposter has the opposite objective.

A normal artist earns points when other players correctly guess the word. The Imposter, however, earns points when other players fail to guess the word. Therefore, the Imposter must deliberately make the drawing confusing, misleading, or incomplete — but not so obviously bad that other players immediately identify them as the Imposter.

The game combines drawing, guessing, deception, suspicion, timing, and risk-taking.

2. Objective of the Game

Each player tries to earn the highest number of points by:

1. Guessing other players' drawings correctly.
2. Drawing well when they are a normal artist.
3. Confusing others when they are the Imposter artist.
4. Correctly identifying and accusing the Imposter at the right time.

The player with the highest score at the end of the game wins.

3. Players

The game works best with **4–8 players**.

Recommended player count:

- **4 players:** playable, but deduction is easier.
 - **5–6 players:** ideal.
 - **7–8 players:** more chaotic and fun, but needs stricter timing.
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4. Key Terms

Artist

The player whose turn it is to draw.

Guessers

All players except the current artist.

Imposter

A secretly assigned player whose goal is to prevent others from guessing correctly when they are drawing.

Turn

One player's 60-second drawing round.

Cycle

One complete rotation in which every player has drawn once.

Example:

If there are 6 players, then 1 cycle = 6 drawing turns.

5. Game Setup

At the start of the game:

1. All players join the game.
2. One player is secretly assigned as the **Imposter**.
3. All players start with **0 points**.
4. The game duration is decided in advance, usually as a fixed number of cycles.

Recommended game length:

- Short game: **2 cycles**
 - Standard game: **3–4 cycles**
 - Long game: **5+ cycles**
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6. Drawing and Guessing Rules

Each turn lasts **60 seconds**.

During a turn:

1. The artist receives a word to draw.
2. The artist starts drawing.
3. The other players type their guesses within 60 seconds.
4. Guessers receive points depending on how quickly they guess correctly.

Guesser Scoring

Time of correct guess	Points awarded
0–20 seconds	30 points
20–40 seconds	20 points
40–60 seconds	10 points
No correct guess	0 points

Only the first correct guess by each player counts.

7. Normal Artist Scoring

If the current artist is **not the Imposter**, they score based on how many players correctly guess the word.

The normal artist receives:

10 points × number of correct guessers

Example:

There are 6 players. One player is drawing, so there are 5 guessers.

If 4 guessers correctly identify the word:

- Each correct guesser gets points based on timing.
- The artist gets **4 × 10 = 40 points**.

The normal artist's goal is to draw clearly enough that as many players as possible guess correctly.

8. Imposter Artist Scoring

If the current artist is the **Imposter**, their scoring is reversed.

The Imposter receives:

20 points × number of players who fail to guess correctly

Example:

There are 6 players. One player is drawing, so there are 5 guessers.

If only 2 guessers correctly identify the word and 3 fail:

- The correct guessers still receive their normal guessing points.
- The Imposter receives **3 × 20 = 60 points**.

The Imposter's goal is to confuse players and reduce the number of correct guesses.

However, the Imposter must be careful. If they draw complete nonsense, they may get many points in that turn, but they also make themselves easier to identify and accuse.

The main skill of the Imposter is **controlled confusion**: drawing badly enough to prevent correct guesses, but subtly enough to avoid suspicion.

9. Accusation Mechanic

Players may accuse the current artist of being the Imposter.

Important rule:

Only the current artist can be accused.

Players cannot accuse random non-drawing players.

This keeps the game focused and prevents chaotic accusation spam.

10. When Accusations Are Allowed

Accusations are **not allowed during the first cycle**.

This means every player must draw at least once before anyone can accuse someone of being the Imposter.

Reason:

The first cycle gives players time to observe drawing styles. Some players may naturally be bad at drawing, so accusations should not happen too early.

After the first cycle is complete, accusations are unlocked.

From that point onward, eligible players may accuse the current artist at any time during that artist's drawing turn.

11. Minimum Score Needed to Accuse

To make an accusation, a player must have a minimum number of points.

The recommended formula is:

$$\text{Minimum accusation score} = 20 \times (\text{number of players} - 1) \times \text{game-length multiplier}$$

Game-Length Multiplier

Game length	Multiplier
2 cycles	0.75×
3–4 cycles	1×
5+ cycles	1.25×

Round the final threshold to the nearest 10 points.

Example Thresholds for a Standard Game

For a standard 3–4 cycle game:

Total players	Minimum score needed to accuse
4 players	60 points
5 players	80 points
6 players	100 points
7 players	120 points
8 players	140 points

This rule ensures that players must participate and earn points before they can make accusations.

12. Accusation Procedure

To accuse the current artist, an eligible player must type an accusation in the chatbox.

Example:

“Imposter”

or

“I accuse”

The game records the time of each accusation.

If multiple players accuse the artist, only the **fastest correct accusation** receives the reward.

13. Correct Accusation

If a player correctly accuses the current artist of being the Imposter:

1. The accuser steals **50% of the Imposter’s current total points**.
2. The Imposter loses those points.
3. The stolen points are added to the accuser’s score.
4. A new Imposter is secretly assigned.

Example:

The Imposter has 120 points.

A player correctly accuses them.

- The accuser gains **60 points**.
- The Imposter loses **60 points**.
- The Imposter now has 60 points remaining.
- A new Imposter is assigned.

If multiple players accuse correctly, only the first valid correct accusation gets the reward.

14. Wrong Accusation

If a player wrongly accuses the current artist of being the Imposter:

1. The accuser loses **50% of their own current points**.
2. Nobody else receives those points.
3. The wrongly accused artist continues normally.

Example:

A player has 100 points and wrongly accuses the artist.

- The accuser loses **50 points**.
- Their score becomes 50.
- No other player gains points.

This makes accusations risky. Players should accuse only when they are reasonably confident.

15. Rounding Rule

Whenever 50% of points creates a decimal, round down.

Examples:

- 101 points $\rightarrow 50\% = 50.5 \rightarrow$ lose or steal 50 points.
 - 75 points $\rightarrow 50\% = 37.5 \rightarrow$ lose or steal 37 points.
 - 41 points $\rightarrow 50\% = 20.5 \rightarrow$ lose or steal 20 points.
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16. Full Turn Flow

Each drawing turn follows this structure:

1. The artist receives a word.
 2. The 60-second timer starts.
 3. The artist draws.
 4. Guessers submit guesses.
 5. Guessers receive points based on correct guess timing.
 6. The artist receives points depending on whether they are normal or the Imposter:
 7. Normal artist: +10 per correct guess.
 8. Imposter artist: +20 per failed guess.
 9. If accusations are unlocked, eligible players may accuse the current artist during the turn.
 10. If the Imposter is correctly caught, 50% of their points are stolen and a new Imposter is assigned.
 11. The next player becomes the artist.
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17. Example Round

There are 6 players: A, B, C, D, E, and F.

Player C is secretly the Imposter.

It is Player C's turn to draw.

The word is "Elephant."

There are 5 guessers: A, B, D, E, and F.

Results:

- A guesses correctly in 15 seconds → A gets 30 points.
- B guesses correctly in 35 seconds → B gets 20 points.
- D, E, and F fail to guess correctly.

Since C is the Imposter:

- C gets points for failed guesses.
- 3 players failed.
- C earns $3 \times 20 = 60$ points.

However, because the drawing was suspicious, Player E accuses C of being the Imposter.

If E is the first correct accuser:

- E steals 50% of C's current score.
- C loses those points.
- A new Imposter is secretly assigned.

18. Strategy

For Normal Artists

- Draw clearly and quickly.
- Focus on the most recognizable features of the word.
- Help as many players as possible guess correctly.
- Avoid drawing so poorly that people suspect you are the Imposter.

For the Imposter

- Do not draw complete nonsense immediately.
- Make the drawing ambiguous.
- Leave out key details.
- Draw something related but misleading.
- Try to look like a normal bad artist, not an obvious saboteur.

For Guessers

- Guess quickly for maximum points.

- Observe drawing behavior across turns.
 - Compare how a player draws normally versus suspiciously.
 - Accuse only when confident because a wrong accusation costs 50% of your own points.
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19. Winning the Game

The game ends after the predetermined number of cycles.

At the end:

1. All final scores are calculated.
2. The player with the highest score wins.

Optional rule:

If the Imposter is still hidden at the end of the game, they receive a final bonus.

Recommended final Imposter bonus:

+50 points if the Imposter remains uncaught at the end of the game.

This makes surviving as the Imposter more rewarding.

20. Recommended Default Settings

For the best first version of the game, use the following settings:

- Players: **5–6**
 - Game length: **3 cycles**
 - Drawing time: **60 seconds**
 - Guessing score:
 - 0–20 sec: 30 points
 - 20–40 sec: 20 points
 - 40–60 sec: 10 points
 - Normal artist score: **+10 per correct guess**
 - Imposter artist score: **+20 per failed guess**
 - Accusations locked during first cycle
 - Accusations allowed only against the current artist
 - Minimum accusation threshold: **$20 \times (\text{players} - 1)$**
 - Correct accusation: steal **50% of Imposter's points**
 - Wrong accusation: lose **50% of own points**
 - Fastest correct accusation gets the reward
 - New Imposter assigned after the old Imposter is caught
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21. One-Line Summary

Imposter Pictionary is a drawing and deception game where normal artists score by helping others guess correctly, while the secret Imposter scores by making others fail — but if the Imposter becomes too obvious, another player can accuse them and steal half their points.